Kanban Board Design

Design a board that shows how work really flows: columns, WIP limits, exit policies and classes of service.

Manage Flow · Visualise the Workflow · Limit WIP · Make Policies Explicit

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

TEAM: Basket team

DATE: 2 April

1 Workflow Columns

LEFT TO RIGHT · ONE COLUMN PER REAL STATE OR QUEUE

COLUMN 1 *e.g. Options*	COLUMN 2 *e.g. Ready*	COLUMN 3 *e.g. Building*	COLUMN 4 *e.g. Waiting for review*	COLUMN 5 *e.g. Testing*	COLUMN 6 *e.g. Ready to release*	COLUMN 7 *Done*
Name: Options	Name: Ready	Name: Building	Name: Review	Name: Testing	Name: To release	Name: Done
WIP limit: none	WIP limit: 4	WIP limit: 3	WIP limit: 2	WIP limit: 2	WIP limit: none	WIP limit: none
Done when (exit policy): Priya has ranked it in the top 10	**Done when (exit policy):** Example-mapped, small enough for a few days	**Done when (exit policy):** Code done, tests pass, pull request raised	**Done when (exit policy):** Reviewed by a second person	**Done when (exit policy):** Exploratory test done; meets WCAG AA	**Done when (exit policy):** On staging and accepted by Priya	**Done when (exit policy):** Released and reorder events seen
☐ Active ☑ Queue	☐ Active ☑ Queue	☑ Active ☐ Queue	☐ Active ☑ Queue	☑ Active ☐ Queue	☐ Active ☑ Queue	☐ Active ☐ Queue

2 Classes of Service

HOW WE TREAT DIFFERENT KINDS OF WORK

CLASS	WHEN TO USE IT	OUR POLICY	LIMIT
Expedite	*Urgent, high cost of delay now*	Swarm on it now; it may break WIP limits	1 at a time
Fixed date	*Value drops after a date*	Start by the latest start date on the card	2
Standard	*Most work, in priority order*	Pull the top item from Ready	the rest
Intangible	*Improvement, tech debt*	At least one item every iteration	1

3 Board Policies

WRITE THEM ON THE BOARD

We pull work when: a column is under its WIP limit

Blocked items are marked by: a pink sticky with the date

Replenishment: when & who: Mondays, Priya and Tom

We walk the board at: 09:30, right to left

Definition of Done lives at: the wall next to the board

Policies reviewed every: quarter, at the retro

4 Cards & Swimlanes

Each card shows:

☑ Title ☑ Owner ☑ Age (days)

☑ Blocked flag ☑ Class of service ☐ Due date

Swimlanes (if any): Expedite lane at the top; no other lanes

5 Flow Metrics to Watch

LEARN, DON'T JUDGE

☑ WIP	*items in progress*	☑ Throughput	*items done per week*
☑ Cycle time	*start to done, in days*	☑ Work item age	*how long open items have run*
☑ Blocked time	*days items spend blocked*	☐ Flow efficiency	*active time / total time* ← *from Q3*

"Where does work wait, and is that visible on our board?"

"What would happen if we lowered this WIP limit by one?"

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